Erasure-Aware Byzantine-Robust Aggregation for Hierarchical UAV-Swarm Federated Learning: When Link Telemetry Hurts

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Abstract—Federated learning (FL) in UAV swarms must tolerate compromised clients and incomplete updates. We study hierarchical FL with packet erasures driven by a measured air-to-ground trace, assumed reference signal-to-noise ratio (SNR) anchors and virtual neighboring base stations. A trusted-reference reputation aggregator is tested with three levels of channel awareness: none, packet-erasure masking, and link telemetry inside the reputation update. A prespecified paired study comprises 720 runs (six aggregators, a clean setting and three model-poisoning attacks, three channel conditions, 10 seeds). The primary telemetry stress interaction is −2.7 percentage points (pp; 95% paired-seed bootstrap confidence interval (CI) [−3.9, −1.5]). Under attack at the 5 dB anchor, masking improves accuracy by 4.2 pp ([2.2, 5.9]) over no-context aggregation, which treats lost packets as zeros, whereas adding telemetry changes it by −3.5 pp ([−5.1, −2.1]) relative to mask-only, accompanied by a rise in honest-update rejection from 13.8% to 41.2%. A constant-evidence drift analysis suggests that asymmetric trust recovery lowers reputation on weak links. In a separate 240-run follow-up on the same seeds, mask-only aggregation outperforms the base paper's fresh-only erasure rule by 19.2 pp under attack at 5 dB ([15.9, 23.0]). FLTrust also gains 19.8 pp over fresh-only, so the large gain reflects shared trusted-reference defense. The signed clean contrast is −2.1 pp (mask-only minus fresh-only; [−2.9, −1.4]).

Index Terms—Federated learning, UAV swarm, Byzantine robustness, packet erasure, hierarchical aggregation, reputation.

I. Introduction

UAV swarms exchange model updates through FL [1], [2], but wireless erasures and malicious updates can coexist. Erasure rules average fresh updates or reuse stale ones [3]; Krum, median and FLTrust address Byzantine clients with complete vectors [4]–[6]. Related work covers analog over-the-air Byzantine aggregation [7], [8], anti-jamming [9] and attacks on reputation [10]. Here we study individually received digital updates with packet erasures.

Link telemetry might prevent unfair penalties for channel-distorted updates. A preliminary single-seed study against a cosine-weighted UAV-FL baseline [11] suggested a benefit. Our controlled hierarchical packet-erasure study finds otherwise. Our contributions are:

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Code, summary results and the scripts that produce every figure: https://github.com/sasank-555/uav-swarm-fl. The raw DeepSense 6G data must be obtained from its provider.

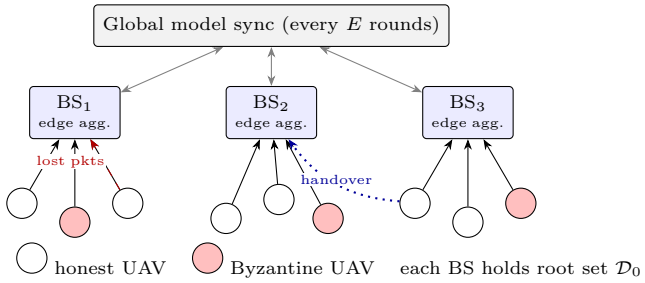


Fig. 1. Schematic of hierarchical UAV-swarm FL: each BS aggregates the (partially received) updates of the UAVs it serves; BS models are synchronized every E rounds.

1) We model hierarchical UAV-swarm FL whose uplink packet erasures are driven by a measured DeepSense 6G drone received-power trace [12], [13], with BS association, handover and model-poisoning attackers.
2) We propose an erasure-aware reputation aggregator and isolate its two channel-aware mechanisms, erasure masking and telemetry-weighted reputation, in a prespecified, paired 720-run simulation study.
3) We identify the zero-drift equilibrium of the reputation update as an expectile of the behavior score [14] and show that it falls as link evidence weakens, consistent with the observed loss from telemetry.

II. System Model

A. Hierarchical learning

K UAVs train a model $\mathbf{w} \in \mathbb{R}^P$ and are served by B base stations (BSs) (Fig. 1). In round t, UAV k attached to BS b starts from the edge model $\mathbf{w}_b^t$, runs local SGD on its private data $\mathcal{D}_k$ and uploads $\mathbf{\Delta}_k^t$. BS b aggregates the updates it receives into $\mathbf{w}_b^{t+1} = \mathbf{w}_b^t + \mathrm{Agg}(\cdot)$. Every E rounds the BS models are averaged, weighted by each cell's number of training samples, and broadcast [15]. Each BS also holds a small root set $\mathcal{D}_0$, disjoint from all UAV data and assumed clean, on which it computes a reference update $\mathbf{r}_b^t$ each round, as in FLTrust [6].

B. Erasure channel

An update is split into packets of L parameters. The uplink SNR γ_k^t of UAV k follows the relative variation of a measured drone received-power sequence [12], [13],

replayed around an assumed reference SNR $\bar{\gamma}$ and adjusted for the 3-D distance to each virtual BS. Conditional on the link state, packets are lost independently, all parameters of a packet sharing one erasure, with probability

$$p_k^t = \big(1 + \exp\big(a(\gamma_k^t - \gamma_{\text{th}})\big)\big)^{-1}, \tag{1}$$

and an update that misses the round deadline is dropped. This curve approximates the normal-approximation error rate with the $\frac{1}{2}\log_2 n$ correction [16] for 32,768-bit packets at 1.58 bits per channel use (about 50% loss at 3 dB), averaged over a fitted 1.7 dB within-round SNR spread: the two agree within 1.0 pp on the plotted SNR grid. The BS therefore observes $\tilde{\boldsymbol{\Delta}}_k = \mathbf{m}_k \odot \boldsymbol{\Delta}_k$, where $\mathbf{m}_k \in \{0,1\}^P$ marks delivered coordinates. Association uses a hysteresis-and-time-to-trigger handover rule on received power. There is no jammer and no additive parameter noise.

C. Threat model

A fixed set of f UAVs is Byzantine. They follow the protocol but replace their update by a sign-flip ($-\lambda\boldsymbol{\Delta}_k$), an ALIE-style update [17] ($\boldsymbol{\mu} - z\boldsymbol{\sigma} \odot \operatorname{sign}(\boldsymbol{\mu})$, from the honest updates of the same cell), or an inner-product-manipulation (IPM) update [18] ($-\epsilon\boldsymbol{\mu}$). The ALIE and IPM attackers observe honest updates in their cell, a deliberately strong assumption. Telemetry is measured by the BS and is assumed authentic.

III. Proposed Erasure-Aware Reputation Aggregation

Let $\mathcal{S}(\mathbf{x}; \mathbf{m})$ restrict $\mathbf{x}$ to the coordinates where $\mathbf{m} = 1$. Each BS runs the following steps (index t dropped).

1) Clipping. With ρ_k the RMS of the delivered entries of $\tilde{\boldsymbol{\Delta}}_k$, scale the update by $s_k = \min(1, \operatorname{med}_j \rho_j/\rho_k)$ (regularized for $\rho_k = 0$), which limits the effect of large-norm updates.

2) Masked similarity. Compare each update with the root update on delivered coordinates only, which removes the zero-fill artifact of lost packets: $c_k = \cos\big(\mathcal{S}(s_k\tilde{\boldsymbol{\Delta}}_k; \mathbf{m}_k), \mathcal{S}(\mathbf{r}; \mathbf{m}_k)\big)$, with $c_k = 0$ for an empty mask or a zero vector.

3) Behavior score. $b_k = \operatorname{clip}\big(c_k/\operatorname{med}_{j:c_j>0} c_j,\, 0,\, 1\big)$, and $b_k = 0$ for all k if no c_j is positive.

4) Reputation. With memory $\beta \in [0, 1)$,

$$T_k \leftarrow T_k + \eta_k\,(b_k - T_k), \qquad \eta_k = \begin{cases} (1-\beta)\,e_k, & b_k > T_k, \\ 1-\beta, & b_k \le T_k, \end{cases} \tag{2}$$

so that bad behavior is penalized at full rate and a weak link cannot shield an attacker that drops its own packets. The evidence $e_k \in [0, 1]$ slows rewards on poor links: $e_k = \text{PDR}_k \cdot R_k \cdot h_k \cdot g_k \cdot v_k$, the product of the packet delivery ratio, long-term reliability, a handover penalty ($h_k = 0.5$ during a handover), a distance factor and a speed factor.

5) Masked weighted average. UAVs with $T_k < \tau$ get zero weight; otherwise $\omega_k = n_k T_k$, with $n_k = |\mathcal{D}_k|$ and a staleness discount. Each coordinate is averaged only over the UAVs that delivered it, and is zero if none did:

$$\text{Agg}_p = \frac{\sum_k \omega_k\, m_{k,p}\, s_k \tilde{\Delta}_{k,p}}{\sum_k \omega_k\, m_{k,p}}. \tag{3}$$

Variants. CCRA (full) uses all steps with telemetry evidence e_k. Mask-only sets $e_k = 1$ but keeps the masks. No-context additionally sets $\mathbf{m}_k = \mathbf{1}$, so lost packets enter steps 1–5 as zeros, which is how a channel-unaware server sees them. With no parameter noise, the code's SINR calibration of c_k is inactive, so full versus mask-only isolates e_k.

IV. Equilibrium Analysis of the Reputation

Consider one UAV with constant evidence $e_k = e \in (0, 1]$ and behavior scores $b \in [0, 1]$ that are i.i.d., independent of its current reputation, with $0 < \mathbb{E}[b] < 1$. By (2), the conditional expected step from level T is $(1-\beta)\, g_e(T)$ with

$$g_e(T) = e\,\mathbb{E}\big[(b-T)^+\big] - \mathbb{E}\big[(T-b)^+\big]. \tag{4}$$

Proposition 1: g_e has a unique zero $T^\star(e) \in (0, 1)$. It equals $\mathbb{E}[b]$ for $e = 1$, is nondecreasing in e, tends to $\operatorname{ess\,inf} b$ as $e \to 0$, and is the expectile of b at level $q = e/(1+e)$ [14].

Proof: g_e is continuous with $g_e(0) = e\,\mathbb{E}[b] > 0$ and $g_e(1) = -\mathbb{E}[1-b] < 0$, so a zero exists. For $T_2 > T_1$, $g_e(T_2) - g_e(T_1)$ lies between $-(T_2 - T_1)$ and $-e(T_2 - T_1)$, so g_e is strictly decreasing and the zero is unique. For $e = 1$, $g_1(T) = \mathbb{E}[b] - T$. Since $g_e(T)$ is nondecreasing in e, a larger e cannot lower the zero. For $T < \operatorname{ess\,inf} b$, $g_e(T) > 0$, so the zero is at least $\operatorname{ess\,inf} b$; for any larger T, $\mathbb{E}[(T-b)^+] > 0$ while $e\,\mathbb{E}[(b-T)^+] \to 0$, so $g_e(T) < 0$ for small e. Dividing $g_e = 0$ by $1 + e$ gives $q\,\mathbb{E}[(b-T)^+] = (1-q)\,\mathbb{E}[(T-b)^+]$, the expectile condition. ∎

$T^\star$ is the zero of the conditional drift, not an almost-sure limit: with $\beta = 0.5$ the reputation keeps fluctuating, and in the simulator e_k and b_k vary over time. Under this approximation, weaker evidence moves the equilibrium from the mean score toward the lower tail of the score distribution. The asymmetry meant to stop packet-dropping attackers can therefore lower the trust of an honest UAV with non-IID data on a weak link, so that it falls below τ more often, while an attacker whose scores are already near zero is suppressed little further. Section V checks whether the gate statistics are consistent with this mechanism.

V. Simulation Results

A. Simulation Setup

Table I lists the values assumed for the parameters. Attackers are chosen per seed and kept fixed across methods. The channel is either ideal or the same measured trace replayed at assumed anchors $\bar{\gamma} = 15$ dB (mean PDR 99.8%) and $\bar{\gamma} = 5$ dB (mean PDR 65.0%). The ideal channel uses different, synthetic geometry: 43.5 handovers per run versus 0.7 on the traces, so it is not a pure erasure-free control. The baselines are FedAvg [1], coordinate-wise

TABLE I
Values Assumed for the Parameters

Parameter	Value
UAVs K; BSs B; attackers f; sync E	10; 3; 3; 5
Rounds; local training	100; one SGD epoch
Model	CNN, 156k parameters
Data	aerial-transformed CIFAR-10, Dirichlet(0.5) [19]
Root set $\lvert\mathcal{D}_0\rvert$; β; τ	500 images; 0.5; 0.3
Packet size L; a; γ_{th}	1024; 1; 3 dB
Reference SNR $\bar{\gamma}$	ideal, 15 dB, 5 dB
Sign flip λ; ALIE z; IPM ϵ	5; 1.5; 0.5
Seeds; runs	10; 720

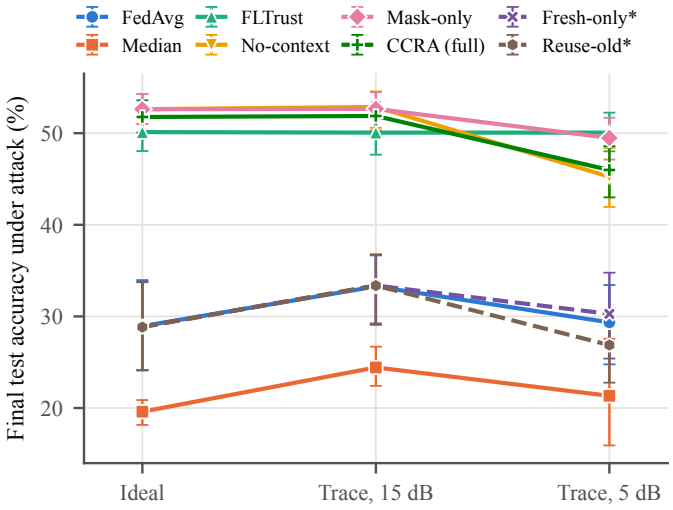


Fig. 2. Final accuracy under attack (mean of sign-flip, ALIE and IPM over 10 seeds; error bars: 95% seed-bootstrap intervals). Dashed, starred rules come from the separate 240-run follow-up. Diverged runs count as 10%.

median [5] and FLTrust [6], which we adapt to the masks: the median ignores erased entries, and FLTrust scores cosine similarity and matches the root norm on delivered coordinates, then averages coordinate-wise. The shared root set receives about 78 optimizer steps per cell-round in FLTrust (the median client budget), versus one epoch (8 steps) in CCRA and its variants; this comparison does not isolate the aggregation rule alone.

The factorial design is $6 \times 4 \times 3 \times 10 = 720$ paired runs, including clean conditions. Numerical divergences count as 10%. The primary telemetry contrast (CCRA minus mask-only at 5 dB minus that at 15 dB) and 1 pp threshold were prespecified. Intervals use 10,000 percentile bootstrap resamples over seeds; other contrasts are exploratory, without multiplicity adjustment.

A separate exploratory 240-run follow-up tests packet-level fresh-only and reuse-old rules [3] on matched seeds 41–50. Fresh-only averages delivered coordinates; reuse-old fills erasures from each client's last received parameters. Both retain the unused 500-image root reserve.

TABLE II
Run outcomes over all 720 runs (120 per method)

Method	Diverged	All runs (%)	Attacked, 5 dB (%)
FedAvg	41/120	37.3	29.4
Median	26/120	29.3	21.3
FLTrust	0/120	50.6	50.1
No-context	0/120	51.4	45.3
Mask-only	0/120	52.8	49.5
CCRA (full)	0/120	51.1	46.0

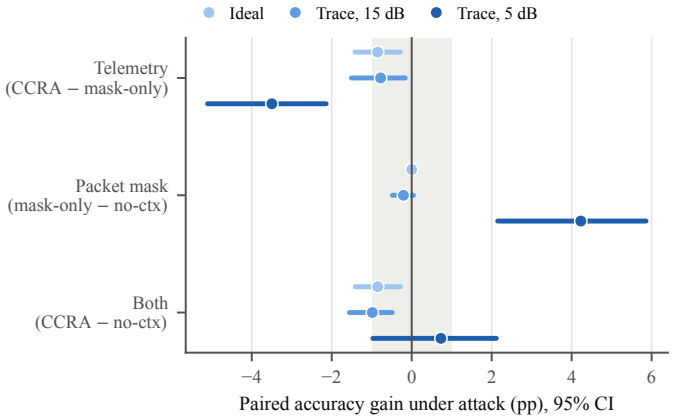


Fig. 3. Paired ablation contrasts under attack. The gray band marks the prespecified ±1 pp region of practical equivalence.

B. Robustness and Stability

Fig. 2 and Table II show that FedAvg and the coordinate-wise median diverged in 41 and 26 of their 120 runs respectively (FedAvg in all 30 sign-flip runs), whereas none of the four root-referenced methods diverged in its 120 runs. Across all runs, mask-only attains the highest mean accuracy (52.8% versus 37.3% for FedAvg). At 5 dB under attack, FLTrust exceeds full CCRA by 4.1 pp (50.1% versus 46.0%). Mask-only gains 2.6 pp against FLTrust ([0.9, 4.5]) under attack at 15 dB, while the 5 dB comparison is inconclusive (−0.6 pp, [−2.0, 1.0]; exploratory).

C. Which Channel Awareness Helps

Fig. 3 separates the two mechanisms. The prespecified stress interaction is −2.7 pp ([−3.9, −1.5]), below the −1 pp practical threshold. On the ideal channel the masks are all ones, so mask-only and no-context coincide. As delivery degrades, erasure masking becomes valuable: at 5 dB it adds 4.2 pp over the zero-filled no-context baseline ([2.2, 5.9]). Telemetry does the opposite: at 5 dB, full CCRA minus mask-only is −3.5 pp ([−5.1, −2.1]; 46.0% versus 49.5%). Combining the two mechanisms leaves an inconclusive net effect relative to no-context. Telemetry also hurts slightly on the ideal channel (−0.8 pp versus mask-only), despite no erasures.

D. Consistency with the Equilibrium Analysis

Consistent with Proposition 1, telemetry raises honest rejection from 13.8% to 41.2%, while attacker acceptance

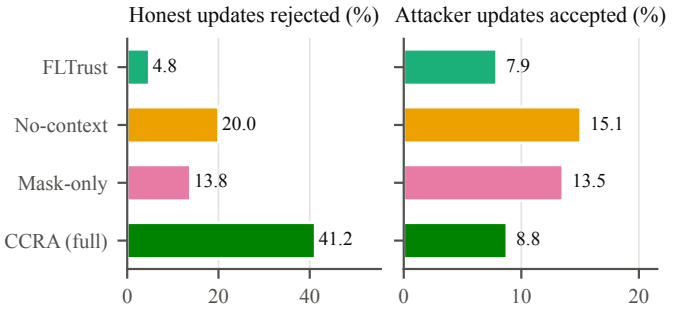


Fig. 4. Reputation-gate decisions under attack at 5 dB, averaged over attacks and seeds (percent of received updates).

falls only from 13.5% to 8.8% (Fig. 4). FLTrust rejects 4.8% of honest updates. Its norm matching, score normalization and weights also differ, so this does not isolate memory. These descriptive rates do not establish causality.

E. Comparison with the Base Paper

Under attack at 5 dB, mask-only attains 49.5% against 30.3% for the better base-paper rule, fresh-only: a paired gain of 19.2 pp ([15.9, 23.0]). FLTrust also gains 19.8 pp over fresh-only. This large gain reflects trusted-reference defense shared with FLTrust; fresh-only already uses delivered-coordinate averaging. It does not isolate masking or the root reference from all other rule differences. The signed clean contrast is -2.1 pp ([-2.9, -1.4]). Fresh-only and reuse-old diverged in 41/120 and 42/120 runs, including every sign-flip run; their clean 5 dB contrast is 5.4 pp. The RTX 2060/GTX 1650 follow-up and A100 ablation agree within 1.1 pp per ideal-channel run, with identical divergences; this does not bound hardware effects under stress. Cross-study contrasts are exploratory.

F. Limitations

We use one measured BS with virtual neighbors about 14 m from it (28 m apart), assumed SNR anchors (the separate channel validation has median SNR 8.6 dB at the 5 dB anchor), and no retransmissions. Ideal and trace geometries differ. We assume a clean root set and use one model and aerial-transformed CIFAR-10. Telemetry spoofing and adaptive reputation attacks [10] are untested.

VI. Conclusion

Masking improves attacked accuracy; telemetry-weighted reputation rejects more honest updates and hurts weak-link performance. The large gain over fresh-only reflects trusted-reference defense shared with FLTrust. Our distinct findings are the masking ablation and telemetry analysis. Future work will revise the reward rule and test fresh seeds, stronger mobility and adaptive attackers.

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